Explain Like I'm 12

One copy-and-paste prompt that turns any difficult topic into a simple explanation - with an everyday example, short sentences, and no textbook language.



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For: Students in school, college and university who meet a topic that feels too hard in the book. **Works with:** ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Muse and other chat AI tools. **Time:** 2 minutes to use, 10 minutes to truly learn from it.

When a topic feels too hard, simplify first

Every student knows this feeling. You read a paragraph three times, you know every word, and still you cannot say what it means. The problem is usually not you - it is the language. Books use long sentences and special words to sound exact, and that hides the simple idea inside.

This shortcut fixes that first step. It asks AI to explain the idea as if you are 12 years old: short sentences, daily-life words, and one example from home, school, sports or cooking. Once the simple picture is clear in your mind, the book language becomes much easier to read.

> **Remember:** Simple does not mean wrong. A good simple explanation keeps the true idea and removes only the hard language. Use it to understand first - then go back and learn the proper terms for your exam.

What this prompt makes AI do

- **Use simple words** - no difficult term without explaining it in the same line.
- **Give a real-life example** - a kitchen, a bicycle, a cricket match, a mobile phone.
- **Go step by step** - one small idea at a time, in the right order.
- **Keep it short** - about 150 to 200 words, so you actually finish reading it.
- **End with a check** - one easy question, so you know if you understood.

Best for these moments

Situation	Example topic
First time learning a topic	What is electricity? What is a cell?
Stuck on a book paragraph	Newton's third law, photosynthesis, supply and demand
Before learning definitions	Atom, fraction, verb tense, climate change
Quick revision	Re-read the simple version the night before a test

The copy-and-paste prompt

Copy the box below exactly. Replace **[TOPIC]** with your topic, paste it into any chat AI, and read the answer slowly.

The Master Prompt ChatGPT - Claude - Gemini - Muse

> Explain [TOPIC] like I am 12 years old. Use very simple English and short sentences. Do not use difficult words - if you must use one, explain it in the same line. Give one example from daily life (home, school, sports or cooking) that makes the idea clear. Go step by step. Keep the whole answer under 200 words. At the end, ask me one easy question to check if I understood.

Tip: Be specific. Write "photosynthesis in a leaf" instead of just "biology", and "fractions - dividing a pizza" instead of just "maths". A specific topic gets a specific example.

Three useful variations

1. Even Simpler - Like I'm 8

> Explain [TOPIC] like I am 8 years old. Use the simplest words you can. Tell it like a short story with one character. Maximum 120 words. No difficult words at all.

Use when: The age-12 answer is still too hard, or you want the very first picture of an idea.

2. One Example Only

> I do not need a full explanation. Explain [TOPIC] using only one real-life example, step by step. Show me where each part of the topic appears inside the example.

Use when: You know the definition but cannot picture it. One strong example often fixes that.

3. Explain, Then Quiz Me

> Explain [TOPIC] like I am 12, with a daily-life example. Then give me 3 easy questions about it, one by one. Wait for my answer each time, tell me if I am right, and explain again simply if I am wrong.

Use when: You want to be sure you learned it, not just read it.

See the difference - Photosynthesis

How the book says it

> Photosynthesis is the process by which green plants synthesise organic compounds from carbon dioxide and water in the presence of sunlight and chlorophyll, releasing oxygen as a by-product.

Correct - but for many students, words like *synthesise* and *organic compounds* stop the learning before it starts.

How Explain Like I'm 12 says it

> Think of a leaf as a tiny kitchen. The plant takes water from the soil, like taking water from a tap. It takes a gas called carbon dioxide from the air. Sunlight works like the stove fire. Using the sunlight, the leaf "cooks" these things and makes its own food - a kind of sugar. While cooking, it also releases oxygen into the air, which is the air we breathe. So photosynthesis simply means: a plant cooking its food using sunlight.

Same true idea. Now you can picture the kitchen, tap and stove - and match each part in the book sentence: sunlight, water, gas in, food and oxygen out.

> **Level up after you understand:** Once the simple version is clear, paste this follow-up: "Now explain the same topic at my class level, with the proper scientific terms, and connect each term to the simple example." This two-step method - simple first, proper second - is how strong students learn fast.

Use AI honestly

Learn, do not copy. Read the simple explanation, close it, and write the idea in your own words. That writing is your real learning.

Check important facts. AI can sometimes be wrong. Compare with your textbook or ask your teacher if something looks strange.

Protect your privacy. Never paste your name, school name, passwords or personal photos into a prompt. A topic name is enough.

Try it now - 3 quick tasks

1. Pick the hardest topic from your current chapter and run the Master Prompt on it.
2. Write its simple explanation in your notebook, in your own words, in 4 to 5 lines.
3. Teach it to a friend or family member using the same daily-life example. If they understand, you have learned it.

More free shortcuts in this series: Summarise Any Chapter - Quiz Me Mode - One-Page Revision Sheet - Difficult Words Made Easy.